

The Worth of Friendship: Can Friends Keep Us Happy and Healthy?

Now that we know of friendship's important role in relation to family, why not make more use of friends when caring for elders?

The now classic book, *Fried Green Tomatoes at the Whistle Stop Café* (Flagg, 1988), and the 1991 movie version, *Fried Green Tomatoes*, reveal the value and meaning of friendship. Intertwined stories follow Evelyn and Ninny, middle-aged and older women in the 1980s developing a close relationship after meeting by chance, with flashbacks to the story of Idgie and Ruth, two young adult women in the 1920s looking after and caring about one another. Themes of affection, companionship, emotional support, solace, practical assistance, loneliness, and health concerns run through the accounts of both pairs of friends and the larger social networks in which they are embedded. These are the same themes researchers have studied while documenting the roles of friends in contemporary adult life.

What Is Friendship?

For many, the definition of “friend” may be taken for granted, yet friendship researchers recognize the existence of many types of friends. They are careful to differentiate across types (based on perceived emotional closeness) and to distinguish feelings and activities relevant to the dif-

ferent types. When people are asked to define friendship, they usually refer to a voluntary tie involving affection, companionship, trust, and reciprocity. They readily understand the meaning of terms such as best friend, close friend, and casual friend, and can easily describe similarities and differences across such friend categories (Adams and Blieszner, 1994; Adams, Blieszner, and de Vries, 2000; Blieszner and Adams, 1992).

Some people acquire new friends throughout life in an ever-expanding web of close bonds.

Note, however, that although friend relationships are voluntary compared to most family bonds, certain restrictions on friendship still hold: people can only befriend people they meet, and even voluntary relationships are subject to social norms (Argyle and Henderson, 1984; Felmlee and Muraco, 2009; Hall, 2011). Some norms, such as reciprocity of self-disclosure and of initiating contact, or mutuality of respect and trust, are reflected in the trust and support elements of the definition of friendship. Other norms, such as the tendency to befriend others who are similar to oneself (whether acknowl-

edged or not) (Adams and Blieszner, 1994) are more subtle.

The emergence of multiple forms of social media, where people can become acquainted with many others via the Internet, changes the definition of friend for some people and expands the range of possible contacts (Huberman, Romero, and Wu, 2008), some of whom may become friends.

Unique Features of Friend Ties

Many family relationships belong to certain segments of the lifespan and depend upon the actions of others. Prepubescent children cannot be parents, intergenerational bonds are contingent upon availability of younger and older family members, and becoming a grandparent occurs not when one chooses, but when one's offspring bear children. In later years, retirement and outliving a child or spouse remove employee and parent or marital roles, respectively. But friendship is a close relationship that begins early and can endure throughout life.

The durability of friendship occurs both because adults sustain longstanding friend ties and because they make new ones. Matthews (2000) identified several distinct approaches to making new friends. Some people have a few longstanding, close friendships and believe it would not be possible to replace such friends if they were lost to relocation, illness, or death. Others are more likely to find new friends as life circumstances change, but to be less intimate with them. Still others acquire new friends throughout life in an ever-expanding web of close bonds. Unlike family relationships that occur through the happenstance of birth or marriage, friend circles resulting from these friendship styles are more influenced by personality, outlook, and choice.

Because friends tend to be age peers, they are more likely than some family members to share attitudes, values, and interests; such perceived commonalities reinforce the development and endurance of friendships. Although friends



might not agree all the time, the voluntary nature of friendship means that positive interactions are likely to outweigh negative ones in ongoing friendships. Companionship and mutual regard are high, and affectionate caring is a dominant feature of the relationship. Unlike the high rate of marital termination through divorce, few people end friendships intentionally, and only due to very serious betrayal or breach of trust (Adams and Blieszner, 1998; Blieszner and Adams, 1998). Most adults report having numerous long-term friends as well as making new ones, suggesting the continued meaningfulness of this relationship across the years (Adams and Blieszner, 1995; Blieszner, 1995).

Changes and Continuities in Friendship Over the Lifespan

Friendships change according to shifting developmental abilities and needs from stage to stage

of life. Toddlers engage in parallel play with playmates, observing and imitating each other as they explore the world together. Preschoolers learn personal initiative while balancing the needs and wants of their friends, but friendships may change frequently. School-age children pursue longer-lasting friendships that supply emotional support and interpersonal validation as they master expectations for learning and productivity. In adolescence, friendships deepen and friend networks expand and receive more attention as teens become increasingly independent of their parents (Blieszner and Roberto, 2004). Adolescent friends can be powerful role models—for good or ill (Piehler, Véronneau, and Dishion, 2012).

Young adults develop the capacity for commitment to lasting friendships as well as romantic relationships. Friends serve as resources and guides for meeting the many new challenges that appear at this stage. Busy middle-aged adults complain of having too little time for friends, yet they manage to sustain and treasure the most important friendships as they confront together the challenges associated with tending family, work, and community needs. Retirees are likely to have more time for keeping in touch with long-term friends who may live at a distance, as well as making new ones for readily available companionship and emotional support. Many older adults thoughtfully choose to develop or sustain those friendships that are most meaningful, while letting others dwindle (Blieszner and Roberto, 2004, 2012; Carstensen, 2006).

Friendships themselves proceed through distinct phases, starting from the tentative period of acquaintance when potential friends first meet, then moving to the formation stage when they arrange continued interaction and opportunities to get to know one another better. During the sustainment phase, emotional closeness may deepen, remain stable, or lessen. Key influences on friendship endurance are perceived similarity on important attitudes and values, shared interests or a willingness to be-

come involved in the friend's pursuits, comfortable amounts and types of self-disclosure, intentional efforts to sustain the friendship, feelings of trust and mutual caring, expressions of social and emotional support, and effective communication and problem-solving strategies for resolving disagreements.

Friends, rather than relatives, tend to have a greater effect on feeling happy and having a positive outlook.

Friendships may diminish in closeness or end completely for a variety of reasons, including changing interests, relocation without sufficient effort to keep in touch, unresolved conflicts, and betrayal. A friend who becomes seriously ill may be unable to sustain the mutuality and reciprocity deemed essential to friendship, and people near the end of life may choose to release friendships in favor of focusing limited emotional energy on close family members (Blieszner and Adams, 1992; Carstensen, 2006).

As research has shown, certain aspects of friend interactions change with developmental stages of life and evolving phases of closeness. Nevertheless, the core elements of friendship—companionship, mutual support, reciprocity, affection—remain consistently stable and important throughout life. Research on friendship among nationalities other than North Americans yields similar findings on the value of friendship well into the later years (among the Dutch: Stevens, Martina, and Westerhof, 2006; Germans: Huxhold, Miche, and Schüz, 2013; Hong Kong Chinese: Siu and Phillips, 2002; Koreans: Park et al., 2013; Swedes: McCamish-Svensson et al., 1999; and the Welsh: Jerrome and Wenger, 1999).

Contributions of Friendship to Health and Well-Being

Friends are important for promoting physical health and psychological well-being. Studies

have shown that friends tend to have a greater effect on feeling happy and having a positive outlook than do relatives (Cable et al., 2013; Huxhold, Miche, and Schüz, 2013), probably because the sense of obligation felt so strongly within family relationships is absent from friendships. Adults are much more likely to rely upon friends than on relatives when it comes to confiding important feelings or seeking solace (Blieszner, 2001), probably because friends tend to be age peers and most people feel comfortable being intimate with those who are similar to themselves rather than with others who may have different life experiences (Gonzaga, 2009).

Friends assist each other with instrumental help such as, in the later years of life, picking up food at the grocery store, providing transportation to medical care, or sharing meals. They also help foster good health by providing information and emotional support, and by helping each other comply with health and medication regimens. They might offer advice about diet and exercise, recommend medical practitioners, listen to each other's needs, enjoy each other's company as they engage in meaningful activities, and laugh together (Gallant, Spitze, and Prohaska, 2007; Moreman, 2008; Resnick et al., 2002). By being involved in one another's lives and showing that they care, by "just being there," friends can mitigate loneliness and depression (Green et al., 2001; Rawlins, 1994), especially in the face of late-life conditions such as chronic health problems or pain (Roberto and Husser, 2007).

In contrast, as with any other close relationship, friendships can be problematic and potentially interfere with health and psychological well-being. If friends do not encourage each other to comply with diet, exercise, medication, or other health-related recommendations, if they offer unsolicited and unhelpful advice, if they are self-centered and cannot reciprocate social and emotional support, if they betray confiden-

ces or trust, or if they do not convey caring and understanding, then they are likely to foster psychological distress and diminish health rather than providing the kind of support that sustains general well-being (Gallant, Spitze, and Prohaska, 2007; Roberto and Husser, 2007).

Implications for Professional Practice

Given the many extensive benefits of friendship, it is important for professionals to consider the variety of ways friends might be tapped to supplement or, in some cases, substitute for aid and emotional sustenance typically provided by family members. Although friends may limit the extent to which they will agree to carry out very personal body care and intensive, ongoing forms of assistance near the end of life (Messerli, Silverstein, and Litwak, 1993), they can certainly continue to provide social and emotional support and companionship for even the frailest individuals. Moreover, for those elders, and for persons who are less frail but still require supervision and assistance because of conditions such as rehabilitation from medical procedures or early memory loss, friends can provide temporary respite for family and professional caregivers who assume the majority of the more involved care and support.

Family and health professionals should solicit respite directly from their loved one's or client's friends, and accept their offers of help.

So it is worth educating older adults about the value of continuing friendship interactions. Friends should not think they will get in the way of family and health professionals. Sometimes people feel they should stay away from their friends in need, not because they don't care, but because they don't know how to proceed. Likewise, it may be necessary to encourage family and health professionals to solicit respite directly from their loved one's or client's friends, and to accept the friends' offers

of visiting, calling, transporting, and otherwise interacting with their loved ones or clients. This kind of friend support would be most likely to occur if it were normalized by including friends (to the extent possible) when developing and executing care plans.

Internet access and social media offer new opportunities for friends to interact with homebound elders, even if the friends are limited in face-to-face interactions because of physical restrictions or geographic distance (see Jobling's article on page 48 of this issue). Friends might be more successful than others in teaching their friends about using such technology as a way of sustaining closeness and support. Community-based programs that encourage friends to work together in this way would be helpful in motivating ongoing interactive support.

Research has shown the promise of direct interventions to promote social integration and mitigate loneliness and isolation due to lack of social skills, social withdrawal, or poor health (Adams and Blieszner, 1993). These programs could be replicated across many communities to extend the benefits to other older adults. For example, Stevens, Martina, and Westerhof (2006) explored the effects of a program designed to educate lonely older women about effective ways to develop new friendships and improve existing ones to help reduce loneliness. Twelve weekly lessons on self-esteem, relational competence, friendship formation and maintenance, and social skills were offered to a treatment group; both treatment and control group members were

assessed on loneliness and friendship information before and after the intervention.

The results showed that compared to the control group, more of the women who received guidance on friendship formation and maintenance had made new friends and more had improved existing friendships at follow-up. Moreover, those who both made new friends and improved existing friend ties reported less loneliness. Women in the treatment group displayed greater increases in taking initiative and a greater tendency to invest in friendship (Martina, Stevens, and Westerhof, 2012), showing they had mastered key friendship skills. The program spots in this issue of *Generations* illustrate other creative strategies for enhancing friendship networks (see Jobling, page 48; Kluge, page 31; McGee and Myers, page 61; McFadden and Koll, page 68; and Roalstad, page 58).

In *Fried Green Tomatoes*, Ninny and Evelyn were capable of developing a friendship without assistance from others, and their growing closeness reduced loneliness for both of them. But those who lack the confidence or skills to initiate friendship may benefit from assistance to guide them toward cultivating satisfying relationships that could meet a variety of needs and contribute to health and happiness. 

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